✈️ World War II: Reading

World History · Unit 7 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with the How did WWII start & Key Battles sheet, Battles slides and Atomic Bomb sheet

Name: _____

World War II (1939-1945)

In 1938 Hitler demanded the Sudetenland, a part of Czechoslovakia. At the Munich Conference, Britain and France agreed, hoping to avoid war. This policy is called appeasement. Czechoslovakia was not even invited. Months later Hitler took the rest of Czechoslovakia. In August 1939 Germany and the Soviet Union signed a nonaggression pact and secretly agreed to divide Poland. On September 1, 1939, Germany invaded Poland, and Britain and France declared war.

Germany used blitzkrieg ('lightning war'), fast attacks combining airplanes and tanks. By spring 1940 it had conquered Denmark, Norway, the Netherlands, Belgium and France. About 300,000 British and French troops were trapped at Dunkirk and evacuated across the English Channel. Prime Minister Winston Churchill refused to negotiate with Hitler. In the Battle of Britain, the Royal Air Force, helped by radar, defeated the German air force and prevented an invasion.

In June 1941 Hitler broke his pact with Stalin and invaded the Soviet Union (Operation Barbarossa) with millions of troops. The Soviets retreated using a scorched-earth policy, burning crops and buildings so the Germans could not use them. On December 7, 1941, Japan attacked the U.S. naval base at Pearl Harbor, and the United States entered the war. President Roosevelt and Churchill agreed to defeat Germany first.

On D-Day, June 6, 1944, Allied forces landed in Normandy, France. Germany's last major offensive, the Battle of the Bulge (December 1944), failed. Germany surrendered on May 8, 1945, VE Day. In the Pacific, the Allies used island hopping. The battles of Iwo Jima and Okinawa were extremely deadly, and Japanese kamikaze pilots crashed planes into ships. Commanders believed an invasion of Japan would cost enormous numbers of lives.

The Manhattan Project secretly built the atomic bomb, first tested at Alamogordo, New Mexico. In August 1945 the United States dropped 'Little Boy' on Hiroshima and 'Fat Man' on Nagasaki. Over 100,000 people were killed, and many survivors suffered radiation sickness. Japan surrendered on August 15, 1945, VJ Day. Historians still debate whether using the bomb was necessary.

Check your reading

1. What was appeasement, and did it work?

2. Why was the Battle of the Bulge important to both sides?

3. What did Allied commanders realize after Iwo Jima and Okinawa?